

Order Passeriformes continued

Family Viduidae

Indigo birds and allies

Length $4\frac{3}{4}$ –13 in (12–33 cm)

Species 20

These African birds are brood parasites of waxbills and munias: females lay their eggs in nests of finches and the surrogate parents raise the young. Different species exploit particular species of estrildids—and have evolved a remarkable degree of mimicry to avoid detection. Their eggs are white (like those of estrildids) and their

LONG-TAILED PARADISE WHYDAH

The female of this species is $4\frac{3}{4}$ in (12 cm), while the male (shown above) is 13 in (33 cm) long—in the breeding season, the magnificent tail of the male adds $8\frac{1}{2}$ in (21 cm) to his length. *Vidua paradisaea* does not build nests, but lays its eggs in the nests of the green-winged pytilia. It is a gregarious bird, and common in eastern and central Africa.

extremely long
tail on male

nestlings have the same gape pattern as host nestlings—an arrangement of white spots in the open mouth—to fool the attending parent. These birds occur in open woodland habitat—wherever their host species lives. Males of one group—called whydahs—develop extraordinarily long tail feathers when breeding.



purple
sheen

DUSKY INDIGOBIRD

Vidua funerea mimics the song of the African firefinch and lays its eggs in the firefinch's nest. Found from Kenya to South Africa, and in parts of West Africa, it is $4\frac{3}{4}$ in (12 cm) long.

Family Estrildidae

Waxbills, munias, and allies

Length $3\frac{1}{2}$ – $5\frac{1}{2}$ in (9–14 cm)

Species 141

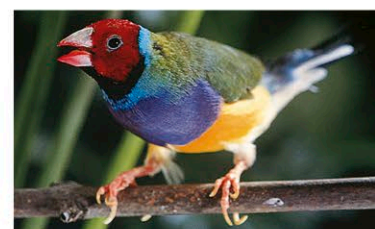
These estrildid finches, a subject of much debate with regard to taxonomy, include waxbills, grass finches, parrot finches, and mannikins, and are found in Africa, Asia, open grassland of Australia, and New Guinea. Largely sedentary, these birds move only to find food or water; they feed mainly on grass seeds. Many of these birds pair for life. Most build domed grass nests, while some nest in holes. They lay 4–8 white eggs, which are incubated for 10–21 days. After the breeding season, they generally become sociable, and flock together for safety.

JAVA SPARROW

Although mainly a bird of towns, large flocks of Java sparrows, *Lonchura oryzivora*, congregate on agricultural land and can become pests. This species, $5\frac{1}{2}$ in (14 cm) long, is endemic to Indonesia from Java to Sulawesi, where it is now rare. It has also been introduced in Asia, Australia, and Tanzania.



orange
cheek
patches



GOULDIAN FINCH

Restricted to savanna woodland, stony hills, and dense grass in northern Australia, *Erythrura gouldiae* is one of the country's most endangered birds, its populations depleted in recent years by infections caused by a mite. It is $5\frac{1}{2}$ in (14 cm) long. Most birds are black-headed, but rarer red- or golden-headed ones also exist.



ZEBRA FINCH

Taeniopygia guttata is 4 in (10 cm) long, and has a black, teardrop-like line below its eye. Found across mainland Australia, it gathers in flocks near water.

Family Nectariniidae

Sunbirds

Length $3\frac{1}{4}$ –9 in (8–22 cm)

Species 143

Found throughout Africa, across Asia, and into Australia, almost all male sunbirds have highly iridescent plumage, while females are usually a dull green. After the breeding season, the males molt into a dull, female-type

plumage. Sunbirds have long bills for collecting nectar and insects, and some have a long tail that is almost half their body length. The 13 species of spiderhunters, although similar to sunbirds, have much longer bills and stouter bodies, and are found only in Southeast Asia. Sunbirds and spiderhunters resemble hummingbirds (see p.329) and feed in a similar fashion but with slower wingbeats. Their nests, made of fine moss and cobwebs, are oval in shape and are usually suspended from twigs and branches. These aggressive

and territorial birds are not migratory, although the pygmy long-tailed sunbird moves annually from Sudan to Congo, and at least 2 other sunbirds move between seasons.



blue-violet upper
body in male

long bill

yellow or
white belly

black tail with
trace of blue

VARIABLE SUNBIRD

Widespread across open savanna woodland and gardens of West, East, and southern Africa, *Cinnyris venustus* is also known as the yellow-bellied sunbird. It is $4\frac{1}{4}$ in (11 cm) long. The male is iridescent blue above with a blue-violet upper breast, while the female is olive-brown above with a buff-white breast.

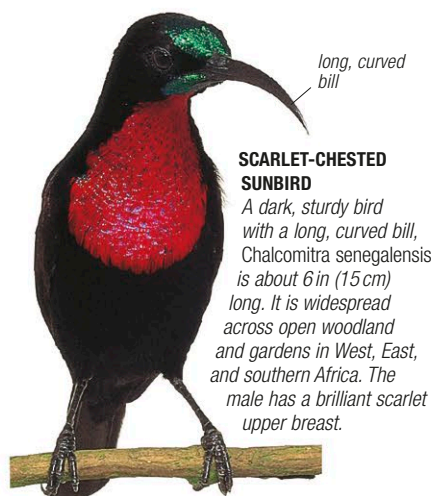
COLLARED SUNBIRD

Found in forests and woodland in sub-Saharan Africa, *Hedydipna collaris collaris* inhabits coastal and riverine woodland. It measures 4 in (10 cm) in length. The male has brighter plumage than the female.



STREAKED SPIDERHUNTER

Arachnothera magna is found in dense forest and overgrown clearings from India to China, and south to Malaysia. It is about $6\frac{1}{2}$ in (17 cm) long, and has a long, downward-curving bill.



long, curved
bill

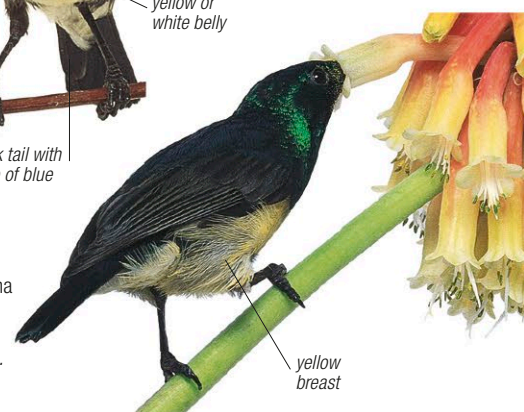
SCARLET-CHESTED SUNBIRD

A dark, sturdy bird with a long, curved bill, *Chalcomitra senegalensis* is about 6 in (15 cm) long. It is widespread across open woodland and gardens in West, East, and southern Africa. The male has a brilliant scarlet upper breast.



PALESTINE SUNBIRD

A scarce bird, *Cinnyris osea* (female shown above), is $4-4\frac{1}{4}$ in (10–11 cm) long. It is found in West Asia and Central Africa.



yellow
breast